



OFF-SIDE

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WHEN SPORT WAS SOMETHING WE DID

As we grow older, **sport can become** something we consume rather than play. But perhaps we lose more than we realise.

There was a time when sport did not need to be scheduled. It just needed a ball and a few willing accomplices.

Much of my childhood cricket was played on the rooftop of a schoolmate's apartment building or in the narrow street in front of our house. Every ball that disappeared over the parapet meant someone had to dash down four floors to retrieve it. And even that inconvenience became a sport. We invented a contest to see who could throw the ball all the way back to the eagerly waiting players on the roof from the road below. Before long, all of us had developed what today would be called a gun throwing arm.

The game had rules that would have bewildered the MCC. One-drop, one-hand catches counted. Hit the wall directly and you were out. The street offered only one legitimate boundary that was straight down. A friend, unwilling to accept such geographical restrictions, perfected a scoop over the wicketkeeper to find the boundary behind. This was years before Tillakaratne Dilshan gave the world the *Dilscoop*.

As we move into adulthood, sport remains in our lives, but our relationship with it changes. We begin by playing it, then watching it and, in some cases, writing about it. Somewhere along that journey, almost without noticing, we cross the boundary from participant to voyeur.

I have been thinking about that boundary lately because my own sporting life has slowly disappeared. There were once two-hour table tennis sessions at the office that were fiercely competitive despite there being

nothing at stake. There was the Saturday morning football with fellow journalists, when reputations built during the working week could be dismantled rather quickly by a misplaced pass or an embarrassing lack of stamina.

Both are now memories.

Perhaps this is simply ageing. Bodies protest, calendars fill up and weekends acquire obligations. Yet something more profound is lost when we stop playing sport. Playing reminds us that sport is difficult. It reminds us that the gap between intention and execution can be enormous. That the pass visible from the stands becomes considerably harder when someone is chasing you. That fatigue alters judgement and pressure tightens muscles.

For those of us who write about sport, perhaps this matters even more.

We demand fitness, courage, discipline and perseverance from athletes. We dissect their mistakes and occasionally question their desire. But when did we last test our own bodies against even the most modest sporting challenge?

Nobody expects a sportswriter to perform like the athletes they cover. But perhaps we should occasionally remember what it feels like to play.

Sport should not become something we merely consume.

And if we spend our lives preaching its virtues, perhaps the least we can do is, at times, practise some of them ourselves.